Shopper Responses to Retail Out-of-Stocks (Public Research Summary)

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This is a summary written in Team 1's own words for the Marvel CPG capstone knowledge base. It is not a copy of the original. Read the original source for full details; cite the original, not this summary, in any formal work.

1 Sources

1. **Helm, R. and Hegenbart, T. (2011).** *Costumer reactions to real out-of-stocks.* Regensburger Diskussionsbeiträge zur Wirtschaftswissenschaft (University of Regensburg Working Papers in Business, Economics and Management Information Systems), No. 458, 20 June 2011. Available from the University of Regensburg publication server: https://epub.uni-regensburg.de/21309/

2. **Grubor, A., Milicevic, N. and Djokic, N. (2017).** The impact of store satisfaction on consumer responses in out-of-stock situations. *Revista Brasileira de Gestão de Negócios (Review of Business Management)*, 19(66), 520-537. Open access via Redalyc: http://www.redalyc.org/articulo.oa?id=94756009002

2 The five ways shoppers respond to an out-of-stock

Research on out-of-stocks groups shopper reactions into five types (as described by Helm and Hegenbart):

1. **Item switch:** buying the same brand in another size, pack or variant.
2. **Brand switch:** buying another brand in the same category.
3. **Store switch:** buying the product in another store on the same day.
4. **Postponement:** buying the product on the next regular shopping trip.
5. **Cancellation:** not buying at all, or not for a long time.

Only the first response keeps the sale for the manufacturer. For the retailer, item and brand switches keep the sale in the store, while store switches and cancellations lose it.

3 What a field study of real stock-outs found

Helm and Hegenbart interviewed shoppers at the checkouts of supermarkets in three retail chains in Germany and Switzerland, right after shoppers had actually met an empty shelf. 205 usable interviews covered 18 product categories, including household products (15.1% of cases).

- **Responses:** store switch 41.5%, postponement 22%, item switch (other size or type) 18.1%, cancellation 12.2%, brand switch 6.3%.
- **Frequency:** about one in ten shoppers reported not finding a product they wanted.
- **Real vs hypothetical:** earlier studies, mostly hypothetical ("what would you do if..."), found more substitution. Real stock-outs produced more store switching and cancellation, so hypothetical surveys may understate the damage.
- **What drives the response:** the availability of an **acceptable alternative product** and **store loyalty** had the biggest effects. Offering acceptable alternatives reduced store switching and cancellation. Loyal shoppers were less likely to switch stores after a one-off stock-out.
- **Timing:** urgency and shopping time mattered. The authors point to empty shelves at the end of the week as a known problem and recommend that retailers, manufacturers and logistics partners secure availability on critical days.

The paper also summarises earlier studies. In a 2002 meta-analysis by Gruen, Corsten and Bharadwaj, as reported in Helm and Hegenbart's Table 1, the average responses were: item switch 19%, brand switch 26%, store switch 31%, postponement 15% and cancellation 9%. Helm and Hegenbart also cite estimates that stock-outs cause

average sales losses of up to about 4%.

4 Store satisfaction (Grubor, Milicevic and Djokic, 2017)

A telephone survey of 392 consumers in Serbia's four largest cities tested how **store satisfaction** affects responses to out-of-stocks. Satisfied shoppers were **less likely to switch stores** and more likely to switch products or postpone. Shoppers who are happy with a store tend to stay with it even when a product is missing.

5 What this means for Marvel's field teams

- **Prevention matters more than substitution.** In the field study, most shoppers either left for another store or did not buy, so a stock-out usually loses the sale for both the store and the manufacturer (MCPG-04, section 2.7).
- **Offer an acceptable alternative.** When a stock-out happens, a same-brand alternative in another size or scent gives the store and Marvel the best chance to keep the sale (MCPG-02).
- **Protect the weekend.** Plan stock so shelves are full before the end-of-week peak; Marvel's data shows weekend sales about 22% above weekdays (MCPG-03).

6 Limitations

- Helm and Hegenbart's study is one field study with 205 interviews in German and Swiss supermarkets across many categories. The responses of Marvel's shoppers may differ.
- The 2002 meta-analysis figures are quoted second-hand from Helm and Hegenbart's summary table.
- Neither study is specific to household cleaning products.

Document control

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Open points and review notes

- Summary written by Team 1; figures checked against the original texts on 20 October 2026.
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